recorded in July 2014, the highest monthly number since the Community Security Trust (CST), the official Jewish body handling communal security, started keeping records in 1984. Significantly, the CST's previous highest monthly total, 289, was recorded in January 2009, at the height of Operation Cast Lead, Israel's first serious attempt to cancel out the Hamas missile threat since withdrawing its forces from the Gaza Strip in 2005.[8] Similarly, in Germany, where the Jewish population has increased from 30,000 immediately after the Second World War to around 150,000 now, government agencies recorded 131 antisemitic incidents in July 2014.[9] Given the relative size of the respective Jewish and Muslim communities in these two countries, Jews are actually much more likely to be targets of hate crimes than are Muslims—a trend already observable in France since 2012, when the Service de Protection de la Communauté Juive (SPCJ,) the French equivalent of the CST, issued a report which noted that 55 percent of racist violence during that year was directed at Jews.[10]

This dovetailing of the frequency of antisemitic attacks in Europe with the troughs and peaks of the Palestinian conflict with Israel is a major factor behind the view that it is Israel's actions which are the primary cause of violence towards Jews. Such an analysis is amplified by the excessive media coverage which this conflict attracts, along with the habit of many press and broadcast outlets alike to portray Israel's military response as a deliberate attempt to wipe out the basic conditions of existence for the Palestinian civilians of Gaza. Empirical research that suggested otherwise, such as that conducted by an Israeli think-tank which pointed out the inherent unreliability of data on fatalities collected by the Hamas-controlled Health Ministry in Gaza, as well as the disproportionately high number of casualties among Gazan males of military age, barely dented this viewpoint.[11]

The net effect of this interpretation was to depict attacks on diaspora Jews as understandable, if misguided. Any analyst examining the character of antisemitism in the early part of the twenty-first century is, sooner or later, compelled to ask: is antisemitism these days a phenomenon that is all in the mind, the phantom creation of a fevered, historically traumatized collective memory? And if the answer to that question is no, then how do we make a credible case that rising antisemitism presents a serious challenge to twenty-first-century civilization?

CONTESTED DEFINITIONS

A large part of the problem, as I have indicated already, resides in the fact that the term "antisemitism" is the most contested of all the terms in the

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